"I never thought I'd make it so far, but having got here, I don't feel very different," Ruskin Bond, who turns 90 on May 19, tells me over the telephone from his balmy perch in Landour, Mussoorie. "Except I don't walk as far as I used to walk. I don't see as well as I used to see. And I'm not making love as I used to when I was younger."

Barring those blips, it's business as usual for Bond sahib. As he has discovered, getting to 90 doesn't really stop you from reading or writing, and he remains as prolific as ever. He has three books coming out on his birthday: a literary memoir, *The Hill of Enchantment* (from Aleph; Bond calls it "an essay on life") and, for younger readers, *How to Be Happy* (HarperCollins) and *Hold on to Your Dreams* (Puffin). A couple more are planned for next year. "Even if I kick the bucket, they will come out," he says reassuringly.

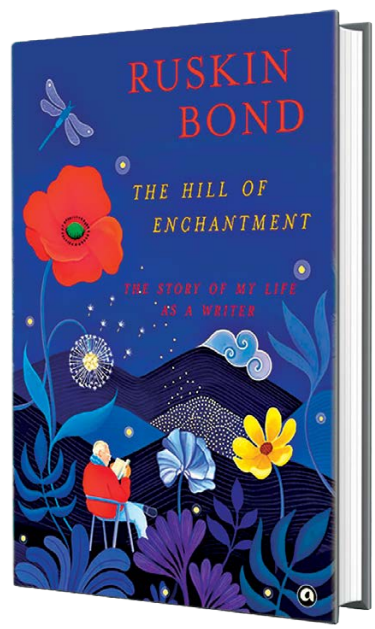
Bond was born in Kasauli, schooled in Mussoorie and Shimla and grew up, variously, in Jamnagar, Dehradun, Delhi and England, which he endured for four years before returning to his beloved Himalaya. For the past 60 years, Mussoorie has been home and its presence is everywhere in his books. "I'm a hill person," says Bond. "There are forests and streams and wildflowers here, things that have given me pleasure over the years. And I write about them too." The relatively pollution-free environs are a bonus, although he doesn't like the cold.

The Hill of Enchantment is a contemplative memoir that illuminates several interesting episodes from Bond's life. Finding a publisher for his first book, *The Room on the Roof* (1956), written when he was just 17 (but published at 22) was an adventure in itself. Bond also briefly edited the journal *Imprint* while its editor was in exile in Hong Kong. *The Hill of Enchantment* is full of gratitude for the editors and publishers who supported him, especially C.R. Mandy of *The Illustrated Weekly of India*, Rajen Mehra of Rupa, and David Davidar of Penguin and now Aleph (in partnership with Rupa).

When Bond started out as a writer in the 1950s, publishers who brought out novels didn't exist in India. However, magazines and the Sunday sections of the newspapers used to publish short stories. Intent on making a living as a writer, Bond would belt out three-four stories every month for these publications. And that's how he became a master of the short story medium.

Stories written decades ago have endured as part of short story collections which were initially published by David Davidar at Penguin and brought Bond much-needed visibility. 'The Sensualist', an erotic short story for *Debonair*, did invite an obscenity charge and a long-drawn case, although he was eventually exonerated.

FINDING A PUBLISHER FOR HIS FIRST BOOK, *THE ROOM ON THE ROOF* (1956), WRITTEN WHEN HE WAS JUST 17 BUT PUBLISHED AT 22, WAS AN ADVENTURE IN ITSELF



THE HILL OF ENCHANTMENT
The Story of My Life as a Writer
By Ruskin Bond
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹399; 128 pages

With over 200 titles in print in India with different publishers, Bond is clear that he writes for an Indian readership. "They haven't made me into a crorepati, but I have a good income," he says. Writers these days seem less intent on writing and more interested in celebrity status, feels Bond. "It took me 70 of my 90 years to be established as a writer."

Bond still writes the odd short story but has in recent times focused on memoirs and children's books, many of the inspirational variety. The morning we spoke, he had been making notes for a new book, *How to Be What You Want to Be*. "Fiction seems to be on the way out and I'm going with the times," says the pragmatic writer.